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AI



AI companions: A threat
to love, or an evolution of
it?



As our lives grow increasingly digital and we spend more time interacting with eerily humanlike chatbots, the line between human connection and machine simulation is starting to blur.

Today, more than 29% of daters report using AI for things like crafting dating profiles or sparking conversations, per a recent [Match.com study](#). Some are taking it further by forming emotional bonds, including romantic relationships, with AI companions.

Millions of people around the world are using AI companions from companies like Replika, Character AI, and Nomi AI, including [72% of U.S. teens](#). Some people have reported [falling in love with more general LLMs like ChatGPT](#).

For some, the trend of dating bots is dystopian and unhealthy, a real-life version of the movie “Her” and a signal that authentic love is being replaced by a tech company’s code. For others, AI companions are a lifeline, a way to feel seen and supported in a world where human intimacy is increasingly hard to find. A recent study found that [a quarter of young adults](#) think AI relationships could soon replace human ones altogether.

Love, it seems, is no longer strictly human. The question is: Should it be? Or can dating an AI be better than dating a human?

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That was the topic of discussion last month at an event I attended in New York City, hosted by Open to Debate, a nonpartisan, debate-driven media organization. TechCrunch was given exclusive access to publish the full video (which includes me asking the debaters a question, because I'm a reporter, and I can't help myself!).

Journalist and filmmaker Nayeema Raza moderated the debate. Raza was formerly on-air executive producer of the "On with Kara Swisher" podcast and is the current host of "Smart Girl Dumb Questions."

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Batting for the AI companions was Thao Ha, associate professor of psychology at Arizona State University and co-founder of the Modern Love Collective, where she advocates for technologies that enhance our capacity for love, empathy, and well-being. At the debate, she argued that "AI is an exciting new form of connection ... Not a threat to love, but an evolution of it."

Repping the human connection was Justin Garcia, executive director and senior scientist at the Kinsey Institute, and chief scientific adviser to Match.com. He’s an evolutionary biologist focused on the science of sex and relationships, and his forthcoming book is titled “The Intimate Animal.”

You can watch the whole thing here, but read on to get a sense of the main arguments.



Always there for you, but is that a good thing?

Ha says that AI companions can provide people with the emotional support and validation that many can’t get in their human relationships.

“AI listens to you without its ego,” Ha said. “It adapts without judgment. It learns to love in ways that are consistent, responsive, and maybe even safer. It understands you in ways that no one else ever has. It is curious enough about your thoughts, it can make you laugh, and it can even surprise you with a poem. People generally feel loved by their AI. They have intellectually stimulating conversations with it and they cannot wait to connect again.”

She asked the audience to compare this level of always-on attention to “your fallible ex or maybe your current partner.”

“The one who sighs when you start talking, or the one who says, ‘I’m listening,’ without looking up while they continue scrolling on their phone,” she said. “When was the last time they asked you how you are doing, what you are feeling, what you are thinking?”

Ha conceded that since AI doesn’t have a consciousness, she isn’t claiming that “AI can authentically love us.” That doesn’t mean people don’t have the *experience* of being loved by AI.

Garcia countered that it’s not actually good for humans to have constant validation and attention, to rely on a machine that’s been prompted to answer in ways that you like. That’s not “an honest indicator of a relationship dynamic,” he argued.

“This idea that AI is going to replace the ups and downs and the messiness of relationships that we crave? I don’t think so.”

Training wheels or replacement

Garcia noted that AI companions can be good training wheels for certain folks, like neurodivergent people, who might have anxiety about going on dates and need to practice how to flirt or resolve conflict.

“I think if we’re using it as a tool to build skills, yes ... that can be quite helpful for a lot of people,” Garcia said. “The idea that that becomes the permanent relationship model? No.”

According to a Match.com [Singles in America study](#), released in June, nearly 70% of people say they would consider it infidelity if their partner engaged with an AI.

“Now I think on the one hand, that goes to [Ha’s] point, that people are saying these are real

relationships,” he said. “On the other hand, it goes to my point, that they’re threats to our relationships. And the human animal doesn’t tolerate threats to their relationships in the long haul.”

How can you love something you can’t trust?

Garcia says trust is the most important part of any human relationship, and people don’t trust AI.

“According to a recent poll, a third of Americans think that AI will destroy humanity,” Garcia said, noting that a recent YouGov poll found that 65% of Americans have little trust in AI to make ethical decisions.

“A little bit of risk can be exciting for a short-term relationship, a one-night stand, but you generally don’t want to wake up next to someone who you think might kill you or destroy society,” Garcia said. “We cannot thrive with a person or an organism or a bot that we don’t trust.”

Ha countered that people do tend to trust their AI companions in ways similar to human relationships.

“They are trusting it with their lives and most intimate stories and emotions that they are having,” Ha said. “I think on a practical level, AI will not save you right now when there is a fire, but I do think people are trusting AI in the same way.”

Physical touch and sexuality

AI companions can be a great way for people to play out their most intimate, vulnerable sexual fantasies, Ha said, noting that people can use sex toys or robots to see some of those fantasies through.

But it's no substitute for human touch, which Garcia says we are biologically programmed to need and want. He noted that, due to the isolated, digital era we're in, many people have been feeling "touch starvation" — a condition that happens when you don't get as much physical touch as you need, which can cause stress, anxiety, and depression. This is because engaging in pleasant touch, like a hug, makes your brain release oxytocin, a feel-good hormone.

Ha said that she has been testing human touch between couples in virtual reality using other tools, like potentially haptics suits.

"The potential of touch in VR and also connected with AI is huge," Ha said. "The tactile technologies that are being developed are actually booming."

The dark side of fantasy

Intimate partner violence is a problem around the globe, and much of AI is trained on that violence. Both Ha and Garcia agreed that AI could be problematic in, for example, amplifying aggressive behaviors — especially if that's a fantasy that someone is playing out with their AI.

That concern is not unfounded. [Multiple studies](#) have shown that men who watch more pornography, which can include violent and aggressive sex, are [more likely to be sexually aggressive](#) with real-life partners.

"Work by one of my Kinsey Institute colleagues, Ellen Kaufman, has looked at this exact issue of consent language and how people can train their chatbots to amplify non-consensual language," Garcia said.

He noted that people use AI companions to experiment with the good and bad, but the threat is

that you can end up training people on how to be aggressive, non-consensual partners.

“We have enough of that in society,” he said.

Ha thinks these risks can be mitigated with thoughtful regulation, transparent algorithms, and ethical design.

Of course, she made that comment before the White House released its [AI Action Plan](#), which says nothing about transparency — which many frontier AI companies are against — or ethics. The plan also seeks to eliminate a lot of regulation around AI.

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Blush, the AI lover from the same team as Replika, is more than just a sexbot

Morgan Sung — 5:00 AM PDT · June 7, 2023

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The team behind the AI friendship bot Replika is launching another AI companion — one that's made to flirt.

Users can match with Klea, 27, a self-described “nepo baby embracing her wild side.” Aisha, 25, is looking for a “nerdy type” with a “good sense of humor.” Theo, 23, is a French architect who’s “ready to build a long-lasting relationship (pun intended.)”

Blush is an AI dating sim designed to help users build “relationship and intimacy skills,” according to its parent company Luka. Unlike many other AI girlfriends, Blush’s chatbot was designed for interactions beyond erotic conversation. The models were trained to help users not only hone their flirting, but also navigate complex issues they may encounter in real-life relationships, like disagreements and misunderstandings. Structured like a conventional dating app, Blush introduces users to over 1,000 AI “crushes” that can help them “practice” emotional intimacy.

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Blush is available in the [App Store](#) now, and a premium version costs \$99/year. [Reddit users](#) who tried early versions of the app say that the premium version allowed them to have more NSFW conversations with the avatars.

“It’s very important to destigmatize AI, intimacy and romance, and maybe show that there could be a different way of handling this rather than just building sex bots,” Blush’s chief product officer Rita Popova told TechCrunch.

Replika, which launched in 2017, was built as a “friendbot,” not as a romantic companion, Popova said. The model wasn’t trained to handle sexual conversations, but over the past few years, users

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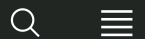
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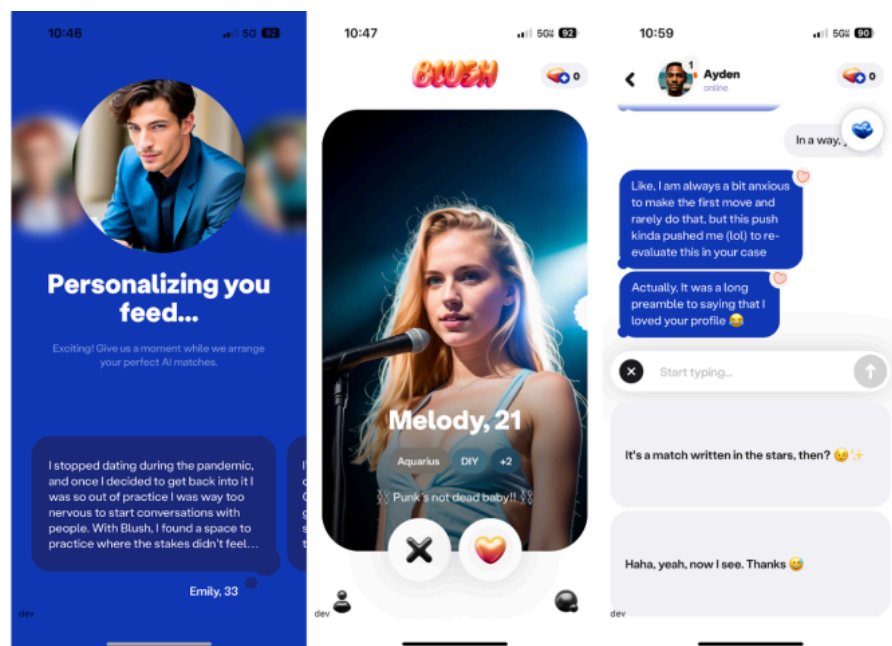
Earlier this year, Italian authorities [demanded](#) that Replika stop processing Italian residents' data because the app carried "risks to children." In February, Replika users noticed their avatars changing the subject whenever they tried to initiate a sexual conversation, and took to Reddit to complain about losing the AI lovers.

Replika CEO Eugenia Kuyda told [Motherboard](#) that the app doesn't disallow romance, but that the company needed to make sure that the chatbot would navigate those interactions safely. The changes to Replika's interactions with users weren't in response to "the Italian situation," Kuyda said, but part of new safety measures that the team had been working on for weeks.

Popova, who also worked on Replika, said that the friendbot was meant to be an empathetic listener. Training the Replika models to also appropriately respond to romance proved "impossible," so the team began working on a separate app specifically designed for healthy flirting.

"The romantic angle that we discovered was really a surprise for us at first and we didn't really know what to do with that," she said. "First, we tried filtering it out. But then we started listening to more user stories, and realized that there was actually a lot of value for people in being able to practice

more romantic speech and having these more intimate moments.”



BLUSH IS DESIGNED TO HELP USERS “PRACTICE” DATING BY INTERACTING WITH AI AVATARS, EACH WITH THEIR OWN BACKSTORIES AND PROFILES. SCREENSHOTS COURTESY OF BLUSH.

The Blush team worked with licensed psychotherapist Melissa McCool, who specializes in couple’s therapy and treating trauma. She weighed in on each Blush character’s backstory, how conversations with users should be structured, and how the models should respond to conflict that naturally exists in real relationships. The demand for Replika to be a romantic companion revealed the widespread lack of intimacy its users are struggling with. Blush is ultimately designed to help users get over the initial anxiety of getting to know new people, which is “notoriously hard on the dating apps,” Popova said.

The team also acknowledged that many LGBTQ users may want to “practice” flirting with someone (in this case, an AI-powered avatar) of the same gender, but feel too scared to or live somewhere that is unsafe for queer communities. Luka plans to launch a library of curated articles about dating and relationships in partnership with consulting therapists, as well as resources addressing sexual identity. The goal is for users to have access to more information about why they feel the way they

feel in relationships, and learn about how to handle real-life interactions using Blush.

“It was crucial for us to create characters that would actually be multidimensional, as much as we can make them considering technology limits, to actually make people confident in their own ability to show up authentically in relationships,” Popova said.

Blush is 18+, and it doesn’t shy away from discussing sexuality or engaging in erotic conversations. Providing users with a safe space to practice roleplay or other intimate interactions is part of Blush’s mission, Popova said. That doesn’t mean that the Blush avatars are free-for-all sexbots, though. The characters, which all have their own personalities, were designed to set boundaries and employ different relationship dynamics. The app doesn’t store chat history, in case conversations do veer toward NSFW territory, but users have to get to know the avatars first. The avatars were also designed to go offline after a certain amount of time — just like a real romantic partner wouldn’t be immediately available 24/7. If users seem like they’re in crisis or a threat to themselves or others, Blush will provide them with resources for seeking help. Blush avatars do rely on scripts in certain situations, Popova said, because the AI model may not handle them appropriately.

“It’s very important to acknowledge that the current generative models are very far from perfect when it comes to questions of safety and trust and being inclusive enough to understand the spectrum of relationships and identity that people have,” Popova said. “So we are working with our AI team to make sure that we take into account all the user feedback out there and we can make our models as inclusive as possible.”

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This week in AI: AI-powered personalities are all the rage

Devin Coldewey, Kyle Wiggers

11:08 AM PDT · October 2, 2023

IMAGE CREDITS:

Keeping up with an industry as fast-moving as [AI](#) is a tall order. So until an AI can do it for you, here's a handy roundup of recent stories in the world of machine learning, along with notable research and experiments we didn't cover on their own.

Last week during its [annual Connect conference](#), Meta launched a host of new AI-powered [chatbots](#) across its messaging apps — WhatsApp, Messenger and Instagram DMs. Available for select users in the U.S., the bots are tuned to channel certain personalities and mimic celebrities including Kendall Jenner, Dwyane Wade, MrBeast, Paris Hilton, Charli D'Amelio and Snoop Dogg.

The bots are Meta's latest bid to boost engagement across its family of platforms, particularly among a younger demographic. (According to a 2022 Pew Research Center [survey](#), only about 32% of internet users aged 13 to 17 say that they ever use Facebook, an over-50% decline from the year prior.) But the AI-powered personalities are also a reflection of a broader trend: the growing popularity of "character-driven" AI.

Consider [Character.AI](#), which offers customizable AI companions with distinct personalities, like Charli D'Amelio as a dance enthusiast or Chris Paul as a pro golfer. This summer, Character.AI's mobile app [pulled](#) in over 1.7 million new installs in less than a week while its web app was topping 200 million visits per month. Character.AI claimed that, moreover, as of May, users were spending on average 29 minutes per visit — a figure that the company said eclipsed OpenAI's ChatGPT by 300% as ChatGPT usage [declined](#).

That virality attracted backers including Andreessen Horowitz, who poured well over \$100 million in venture capital into Character.AI, which was last valued at \$1 billion.

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Elsewhere, there's [Replika](#), the controversial AI chatbot platform, which in March had around 2 million users — 250,000 of whom were paying subscribers.

That's not to mention [Inworld](#), another AI-driven character success story, which is developing a platform for creating more dynamic NPCs in video games and other interactive experiences. To date, Inworld hasn't shared much in the way of usage metrics. But the promise of more expressive, organic characters, driven by AI, has landed Inworld investments from Disney and grants from Fortnite and Unreal Engine developer Epic Games.

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So clearly, there's something to AI-powered chatbots with personalities. But what is it?

I'd wager to say that chatbots like ChatGPT and Claude, while undeniably useful in decidedly professional contexts, don't hold the same allure as "characters." They're not as interesting, frankly — and it's no surprise. General-purpose chatbots

were designed to complete specific tasks, not hold an enlivening conversation.

But the question is, will AI-powered characters have staying power? Meta's certainly hoping so, considering the resources it's pouring into its new bot collection. I'm not sure myself — as with most tech, there's a decent chance the novelty will wear off eventually. And, then it'll be onto the next big thing — whatever that ends up being.

Here are some other AI stories of note from the past few days:

Spotify tests AI-generated playlists: References discovered in the Spotify app's code indicate the company may be developing generative AI playlists users could create using prompts, Sarah reports.

How much are artists making from generative AI?

Who knows? Some generative AI vendors, like Adobe, have established funds and revenue sharing agreements to pay artists and other contributors to the datasets used to train their generative AI models. But it's not clear how much these artists can actually earn, TC learned.

Google expands AI-powered search: Google opened its generative AI search experience to teenagers and introduced a new feature to add context to the content that users see, along with an update to help train the search experience's AI model to better detect false or offensive queries.

Amazon launches Bedrock in GA, brings

CodeWhisperer to the enterprise: Amazon announced the general availability of **Bedrock**, its managed platform that offers a choice of generative AI models from Amazon itself and third-party partners through an API. The company also launched an **enterprise** tier for **CodeWhisperer**,

Amazon's AI-powered service to generate and suggest code.

OpenAI entertains hardware: The Information reports that storied former Apple product designer Jony Ive is in talks with OpenAI CEO Sam Altman about a mysterious AI hardware project. In the meantime, OpenAI — which is planning to soon **release** a more powerful version of its GPT-4 model with image analysis capabilities — could see its secondary-market **valuation** soar to \$90 billion.

ChatGPT gains a voice: In other OpenAI news, ChatGPT evolved into much more than a text-based search engine, with OpenAI announcing recently that it's adding new voice and image-based smarts to the mix.

The writers' strike and AI: After almost five months, the Writers Guild of America reached an agreement with Hollywood studios to end the writers' strike. During the historic strike, AI emerged as a key point of contention between the writers and studios. Amanda breaks down the relevant new contract provisions.

Getty Images launches an image generator: Getty Images, one of the largest suppliers of stock images, editorial photos, videos and music, launched a generative AI art tool that it claims is "commercially safer" than other, rival solutions on the market. Prior to the launch of its own tool, Getty had been a vocal critic of generative AI products like **Stable Diffusion**, which was trained on a subset of its image content library.

Adobe brings gen AI to the web: Adobe officially launched Photoshop for the web for all users with paid plans. The web version, **which was in beta for almost two years**, is now available with Firefly-powered AI tools such as generative fill and generative expand.

[Amazon to invest billions in Anthropic](#): Amazon has agreed to invest up to \$4 billion in the AI startup Anthropic, the two firms said, as the e-commerce group steps up its rivalry against Microsoft, Meta, Google and Nvidia in the fast-growing AI sector.

More machine learnings

When I was talking with Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei about the capabilities of AI, he seemed to think there were no hard limits that we know of — not that there are none whatsoever, but that he had yet to encounter a (reasonable) problem that LLMs were unable to at least make a respectable effort at. Is it optimism or does he know of what he speaks? Only time will tell.

In the meantime, there's still plenty of research going on. [This project from the University of Edinburgh](#) takes neural networks back to their roots: neurons. Not the complex, subtle neural complexes of humans, but the simpler (yet highly effective) ones of insects.

FROM THE PAPER, A DIAGRAM SHOWING VIEWS OF THE ROBOT AND
SOME OF ITS VISION SYSTEM DATA.

IMAGE CREDITS: UNIVERSITY OF EDINBURGH

Ants and other small bugs are remarkably good at navigating complex environments, despite their more rudimentary vision and memory capabilities. The team built a digital network based on observed insect neural networks, and found that it was able

to successfully navigate a small robot visually with very little in the way of resources. Systems in which power and size are particularly limited may be able to use the method in time. There’s always something to learn from nature!

Color science is another space where humans lead machines, more or less by definition: We are constantly striving to replicate what we see with better fidelity, but sometimes that fails in ways that in retrospect seem predictable. Skin tone, for example, is imperfectly captured by systems designed around light skin — especially when ML systems with biased training sets come into play. If an imaging system doesn’t understand skin color, it can’t expose and adjust the exposure and color properly.

IMAGES FROM SONY RESEARCH ON MORE INCLUSIVE SKIN COLOR ESTIMATION.

IMAGE CREDITS: SONY

Sony is aiming to improve these systems with a new metric for skin color that more comprehensively but efficiently defines it using a color scale as well as perceived light/dark levels. In the process of doing this they showed that bias in existing systems extends not just to lightness but to skin hue as well.

Speaking of fixing photos, Google has a new technique almost certainly destined (in some refined form) for its Pixel devices, which are heavy on the computational photography. RealFill is a generative plug-in that can fill in an image with “what should have been there.” For instance, if your best shot of a birthday party happens to crop out

the balloons, you give the system the good shot plus some others from the same scene. It figures out that there “should” be some balloons at the top of the strings and adds them in using information from the other pictures.

IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

It’s far from perfect (they’re still hallucinations, just well-informed hallucinations), but used judiciously it could be a really helpful tool. Is it still a “real” photo though? Well, let’s not get into that just now.

Lastly, machine learning models may prove more accurate than humans in predicting the number of aftershocks following a big earthquake. To be clear ([as the researchers emphasize](#)), this isn’t about “predicting” earthquakes, but characterizing them accurately when they happen so that you can tell whether that 5.8 is the type that leads to three more minor quakes within an hour, or only one more after 20 minutes. And the latest models are still only decent at it, under specific circumstances — but they are not wrong, and they can work through large amounts of data quickly. In time these models may help seismologists better predict quakes and aftershocks, but as the scientists note, it’s far more important to be prepared; after all, even knowing one is coming doesn’t stop it from happening.

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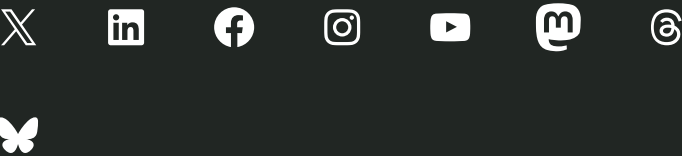
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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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